

THE CONTINUING SCANDAL (Facing) Protesters demand a CBI inquiry into the REET scam; (inset) sacked chairman of the state board of secondary education D.P Jaroli; CM Gehlot with MoS Subhash Garg

recruitment processes and announced that laws will be enacted to increase the seriousness of punishments.

Nonetheless, these efforts have not doused public anger. Opposition leaders have also remained relentless in their attack, aided by the frequent revelations from the investigation. Kirodi Lal Meena, a BJP MP who has been among the government's fiercest critics through the crisis, has been demanding that the investigation be handed over to the CBI (Central Bureau of Investigation). He says the entire REET process was a money-making exercise, and that there was corruption in every step. He has especially targeted Govind Singh Dotasra, PCC president and education minister at the time the exam took place, as well as MoS Subhash Garg. In 2020, Gehlot had made Dotasra PCC chief in place of Sachin Pilot. Garg is an MLA from the Rashtriya Lok Dal and a minister, known to be close to the CM.

Meena has also accused Dotasra of arranging for the paper to be leaked through a coaching institute in his constituency, Sikar, alleging that a bank of 2,000 questions from which the final paper was to be set was also sold. He argues that only a CBI inquiry will do, saying leaders holding sensitive offices are involved. Vasudev Devnani, a BJP MLA and former education minister, says, "There is no smoke without fire, and in this REET fire, the Gehlot government has been severely harmed."

On January 30, Meena made an explosive allegation, saying nine RGSC members had been 'handpicked to oversee' the REET examinations in important districts, allegedly to facilitate cheating. In Jaipur, for example, the person chosen, he says, was Pradeep Prashar, despite him having no other official position. Ram Kirpal Meena, who runs an educational institute, was chosen as deputy coordinator, against oral orders. Both Prashar and Ram Kirpal have been arrested—the latter is believed to have been part of the group handling the transport of question papers from the education department's strongroom at its HQ in Jaipur to the various districts. The leaked paper is believed to have been stolen at this point. There is also evidence that Jaroli was present in the building when this happened, though he has denied it.

Responding to the allegations, Dotasra has said the SOG should be given time to complete its investigations. Garg says he is being targeted because of his quick political rise, and also attempted to spin the accusation back, suggesting that the SOG probe whether Meena himself has links to gangs involved in similar crimes. And despite demands that the REET results be cancelled and the exam be conducted again, CM Gehlot has refused, saying it would be unfair to those who qualified honestly. The state is also opposed to a CBI inquiry, likely fearing the BJP-led central government will use it to embarrass the Rajasthan government.

Yet, the fallout of the scam does not look like it will be going away anytime soon, already ranking on par with the crisis that enveloped the state during the failed Pilot rebellion in 2020. Incidentally, Pilot himself has long been opposed to both Garg and Dotasra. He recently broke his silence on the REET issue, arguing for a transparent inquiry and for the guilty to be punished to restore people's confidence in the system. Opposition members hope the Rajasthan High Court, which is hearing petitions to cancel the REET results and order a CBI inquiry, is disposed to do the latter. One way or another, the road ahead for Rajasthan Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot is a rocky one. ■

THE PRICE OF A LEAK

₹5 crore
THE AMOUNT THE QUESTION PAPER IS BELIEVED TO HAVE BEEN SOLD FOR IMMEDIATELY AFTER IT WAS STOLEN

51
THE NUMBER OF APPLICANTS PER POST IN THE 2021 REET: THERE WERE 31,000 POSTS AND 1.6 MILLION CANDIDATES

36
THE NUMBER OF PEOPLE ARRESTED IN THE ONGOING INVESTIGATION SINCE THE REET SCAM CAME TO LIGHT